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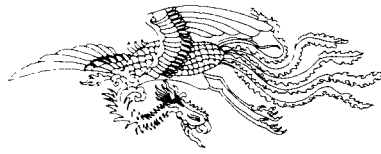
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“A very rare and difficult thing”
Ecofeminism, Attention to Animal Suffering
and the Disappearance of the Subject

CAROL ADAMS

“The capacity to give one’s attention to a sufferer is a very rare and difficult thing; it is almost a miracle; it *is* a miracle.”

—Simone Weil

This essay is an ecofeminist exploration of two out-of-place cows and what they teach us about several interrelated issues regarding the religious imagination and human relations with non-humans. The first cow was fashioned by filmmaker David Lynch for the “Cow Parade,” a collection of artily painted sculptured bovines scattered throughout New York City in 2000. Lynch’s painted cow had “Eat My Fear” written across its hacked, decapitated, and disemboweled body. This cow appeared in the cow parade for two and a half hours, but caused children to cry and subsequently was kept under wraps in a warehouse. The other cow, an actual cow, jumped a six-foot fence in Cincinnati in the winter of 2002 to escape a meatpacking plant and then, until she was captured, ran free in a city park for ten days. The day after Easter, she appeared in a parade that celebrated the start of the baseball season. Now called, “Cinci Freedom,” she received a key to the city as part of the city’s festivities. She was then transported to an animal sanctuary to live out her natural life

unmolested by meat packers, while many of the humans who celebrated her freedom headed to the ballpark to watch baseball and chomp down on some hot dogs. Ecofeminist insights offer assistance in unraveling the paradoxes concerning nonhuman suffering inherent in these stories.

Through the lens of ecofeminism, a celebrated escapee from the clutches of meatpackers, a banished reminder of what meat eating is, and quotidian hot dogs teach us about structures that enable suffering. If humans want to talk about human-nonhuman relationships, they must bring attention to the 95 percent of the nonhumans whose suffering is caused by humans—*terminal animals*, that is, the nonhumans used in the food industry to produce milk, eggs, and flesh (the cows that Cinci Freedom left behind at the meat packers for instance). Every day good people participate in activities that cause the suffering of these terminal animals. Why do they seem to care so little about this suffering? They care so little because of the cultivated disappearance of the subject.

Not only does the *subject of suffering* disappear, especially when the issue is reframed as being about “existence” rather than suffering, but also the subject who is suffering disappears, like the “Eat My Fear” cow locked in a warehouse. The suffering remains invisible. Further, the subject (the individual human who eats nonhumans) who is *causing* the suffering disappears, the agential role of requiring the existence of terminal animals is hard to pinpoint during the enjoyable pastime of watching a ball game and eating a hot dog or hamburger. Finally, the issue of suffering disappears because, religiously speaking, knowledge of suffering requires attention; the process of following attention can lead to grief, and how we experience grief is messy—bodily—and humans have been socialized to fear the body.

Following Weil’s thought, the religious imagination, I would submit, is the capacity to recognize the possibility of relationships and bring attention to suffering: “Not only does the love of God have attention for its substance; the love of our neighbour, which we know to be the same love, is made of this same substance” (Weil 1971:75). Cinci Freedom, safe at an animal sanctuary in upstate New York, became a “neighbor.” Ecofeminist theory helps us identify why it is that nonhumans have not usually been included in our conception of “neighbors.” Ecofeminism, while bringing awareness of our culture’s failure in certain areas of relationships, reminds us how much humans are truly in community with all living beings. It therefore aids in understanding humans’ relationship to the disappearance of the subject of nonhuman suffering.

Ecofeminist Frameworks

Ecofeminism posits that the domination of the rest of nature is linked to the domination of women and that both dominations must be eradicated. To the issues of sexism, racism, classism, and heterosexism that concern feminists, ecofeminists add naturism—the oppression of

the rest of nature. Many ecofeminist writers have demonstrated how the exploitation of non-human animals is an aspect of naturism, incorporating specific attention to the status of the other animals into a larger critique of the maltreatment of the natural world.¹

Ecofeminist philosopher Karen Warren (1987, 1990) identifies three significant features of an oppressive or patriarchal conceptual framework: dualistic thinking, value-hierarchical thinking, and “the glue that holds it all together” (personal communication)—a logic of domination. “Up-down” or “*value-hierarchical thinking*” places higher value, status, or prestige on what is up rather than what is down. Elisabeth Schüssler-Fiorenza calls this “*kyriarchal*” (i.e., rule of the master or lord) in which elite propertied men have power over those subordinate and dependent on them. In such hierarchies, men are “up,” women are “down”; culture is “up,” nature is “down.” Species is theorized hierarchically, so that humans are “up,” the other animals are “down”; hot dog eaters, for instance, are “up” and cows are “down.” Humans are not only seen as above the other animals, but also as opposed to them in terms of interests and abilities. This is an aspect of *dualistic thinking*. Warren continues, “Patriarchal value-hierarchical thinking supports the sort of ‘either-or’ thinking which generates *normative dualisms*, i.e., thinking in which the disjunctive terms (or sides of the dualism) are seen as exclusive (rather than inclusive) and oppositional (rather than complementary), and where higher value or superiority is attributed to one disjunct (or, side of the dualism) than the other” (Warren 1987:6).

Dualisms reduce diversity to two categories: A or Not A. They convey the impression that everything can then be appropriately categorized: *either it is A or Not A*. Ecofeminist philosopher Val Plumwood calls dualism “the logic of colonisation” (Plumwood 1993:41). Plumwood (1993:43) identifies the key elements in the dualistic structure of Western thought as:

culture / nature
 reason / nature
 male / female
 mind / body (nature)
 master / slave
 reason / matter (physicality)
 rationality / animality (nature)
 reason / emotion (nature)
 mind/spirit / nature
 freedom / nature
 universal / particular
 human / nature (nonhuman)
 civilised / primitive (nature)
 production / reproduction (nature)
 public / private
 subject / object
 self / other

Through dualistic thinking, humans are conceptualized both as “not animals” and as “better than animals.” In a similar manner, dualisms give higher value or status to that which has historically been identified as “mind,” “reason,” and “male” than to that which has historically been identified as “body,” “emotion,” and “female” (Warren 1987:20). As Plumwood points out, the mind or “reason” is constructed to exclude nature, so nature (and nonhuman animals) is constructed as mindless (Plumwood 1993:107). Such radical exclusiveness positions nature as oppositional and alien to humans. The result is that differences are “naturalized,” so much so that construction of humans’ notion of themselves is based on “hyperseparation.” We look at nature and nonhuman animals and there is no neighbor there.

Historically, men positioned themselves as being morally superior to women and a male-identified humanity similarly positioned itself as being morally superior to animals (with whom women are often equated). Together value hierarchical thinking and dualistic structures are entangled within a logic of domination “which explains, justifies, and maintains the subordination of an ‘inferior’ group by a ‘superior’ group

on the grounds of the (alleged) inferiority or superiority of the respective group” (Warren 1987:6). So superiority justifies subordination.

Justification for the consumption of animals intertwines dualistic thinking, value-hierarchical thinking, and the logic of domination: Human beings are different from animals. Human beings are superior to animals. By virtue of that difference and concomitant superiority, humans have the right to eat animals. But to reduce any guilt, or other potent feelings (see Luke 1992, 1995), that might exist about eating animals, humans are also told the lie that because humans are a kind and caring species, the animals live comfortable lives until they are humanely slaughtered. We need not be attentive to suffering because no suffering exists, or so those on the “up” side propose.²

Transcending the Animal

Because of dualistic thinking, descriptions of human beings exclude the animal or animal-like. Humans are intelligent, nonhumans are instinctive; humans love, nonhumans mate; humans cultivate friendships, nonhumans have “affiliative behavior;” humans are humane, refined, nonhumans are beasts, brutal.³ Like the “animal” — cut off from any association with the “human” — the animal-like, especially the body, is disowned.

As feminist philosophers have pointed out, the Western definition of the man of reason was that he could overcome body, history, social situations, and thereby gain knowledge of others he examined as objects. “Western philosophers have for the most part assigned a lower ontological status to the body than to whatever must hold this body, with its propensity of moral and epistemological error, in check: *nous*; spirit; soul; rational intuition” (Bartky 1989:78). Disembodied rationality proclaims that the body is an “organ of the deceptive senses” (Bordo 1987:450). The idea of the “man

of reason" draws upon "men's gender-specific criteria" (Harding 1986:48) and more highly values activities identified as male or "masculine." Reason is defined as the antithesis of what is thought to be female. "[T]he feminine has been associated with what rational knowledge transcends, dominates or simply leaves behind" (Lloyd 1984:2)—emotions, feelings, and body.

Consequently, emotions have been denigrated as untrustworthy and unreliable, as invalid sources of knowledge. Feminist philosopher Elizabeth Spelman refers to this as *somatophobia*: hostility to the body. The legacy of the soul/body distinction, Spelman believes, is that it is used to denigrate women, children, animals, and "the natural" who are guilty by association with one another and with the body (Spelman 1982:120, 127). The body, identified with animals, is what must be transcended. A rational, objective knowing person is one who esteems autonomy over relationship, hyperseparation over attention.

The rational/feeling dualism follows the fault line of a culture in which white, upper-class men have shaped the philosophical and religious discussions for centuries, a fault line that adheres to gender, class, race, and species assumptions. According to feminist and ecofeminist insights, modern epistemology and its suspicion of emotions, its dualistic ontologies, its rationalist bias, its concern for achieving objectivity, and its avoidance of sympathy as a basis for ethical treatment—these all may represent not some universal response, but a very specific one: the response to the experience of being an elite human male.

Constituting the Subject

The most efficient way to ensure that humans are not reminded of animals' suffering and our role in it is to transform nonhuman subjects into nonhuman objects. *Someone* becomes *something*, a *who* becomes a *that*, ultimately, the liv-

ing are made (as) dead, and the process of reification triumphs. Who is suffering? No one.

What we think of as a one-directional process, the disappearance of the nonhuman subject, is in fact bi-directional—related to the construction of the human (male-identified, body-denying) subject. Subjectivity is constructed hierarchically and dualistically. Subjectivity for the "up" side of a value hierarchical dualistic world exists in relationship to the object status of those on the "down" side. While our species is capable of a great range of behavior, the cultural relationship paradigmatic in the West is one of subject to object, in fact, subject *over* object. As dualistic apprehensions of the world take on the appearance of reality, our notions of human subjectivity depend, in part, on the presumed object status of nonhumans. The process of subjectification is thus dependent on depriving subject-status to another subject. This is how, in cultures of dominance and subordination, a subject knows he (or she) is a subject—through relationship to an object. Val Plumwood explains, "In the egoist-instrumentalist model (the master model of self), the self erases the other as part of the ethical domain" (Plumwood 1993:145). The other is seen as interchangeable and is experienced only in terms of the dominant self's need for gratification. The dualistic subject is trained to remain untransformed by the other, the objectified subject. No real interaction can occur because it is too threatening to the dominant self's private desire. (This is the reason Weil sees attention as so miraculous, the self is able to overcome the very desires that require the suffering of another.) Attention is further discouraged by constructs that hide the subject-status of terminal animals.

The Disappearance of the Nonhuman Subject

What if Cinci Freedom had not leapt over the six-foot fence at the meatpackers? What

structurally oppressive frameworks would have butchered any concern for her just as the meat packers were set to butcher her literal body?

Behind every meal of meat is an absence: the death of the nonhuman whose place the product takes. The *absent referent* is that which separates the consumer from the animal and the animal from the end product. If nonhumans are alive they cannot be meat. Thus a dead body replaces the live nonhuman and nonhumans are conceptually absent from the act of eating flesh because they have been transformed into food.

The function of the absent referent is to keep our “meat” separated from any idea that she or he was once an animal, to keep the “moo” or “cluck” or “baa” away from the meat, to keep *something* from being seen as having been *someone*. Cow becomes “beef,” pig becomes “pork.” In cases in which slaughtered nonhumans carry the same name before and after their deaths, e.g., “chicken,” “duck,” “turkey,” the absent referent is still at work. Their body parts are labeled without any possessiveness attributed to the nonhuman, that is, a lamb’s leg becomes “leg of lamb,” many chickens’ wings become chicken wings. Once the existence of flesh is disconnected from the existence of a nonhuman who was killed to become that product, “meat” becomes unanchored by its original referent (the animal), becoming instead a free-floating image, a metaphor, unbloodied by suffering. David Lynch’s Cow Parade entry, “Eat My Fear” disturbed the structure of the absent referent. It was too graphic a reminder that someone is suffering: as she or he becomes something.

Had Cinci Freedom not leapt over the wall, she would have been interchangeable with the cows who were killed that day. In our culture, “meat” operates as a mass term (see Quine 1960: 99), defining entire species of nonhumans. Mass terms refer to things like water or colors; no matter how much you have of it, or what type of container it is in, it is still water. You can add a bucket of water to a pool of water without

changing it at all. Objects referred to by mass terms have no individuality, no uniqueness, no specificity, no particularity. When humans turn a nonhuman into “meat,” someone who has a very particular, situated life, a unique being, our neighbor, is converted into something that has no distinctiveness, no uniqueness, no individuality. When one adds five pounds of hamburger to a plate of hamburger, it is more of the same thing, nothing is changed. But to have a living cow, Cinci Freedom for instance, and then kill that cow, and butcher that cow, and grind up her flesh, you have not added a mass term to a mass term and ended up with more of the same. You have destroyed an individual. You have injured a neighbor. What is on the table in front of us is not devoid of specificity. It is the dead flesh of what was once a living, feeling being. The crucial point here is that humans make someone who is a unique being and therefore not the appropriate referent of a mass term into something that is the appropriate referent of a mass term. Humans make a subject into an object. Humans do so by removing any associations that might make it difficult to accept the activity of rendering a unique individual into a consumable thing. Not wanting to be aware of this activity, humans accept this disassociation, this distancing device of the mass term “meat.”

The majority of nonhumans dominated by humans have been so devalued they no longer appear to be a part of nature, so thoroughly trivialized by their mass term status that it seems impossible to find meaning in their individual lives. A dualistic understanding of nonhumans who are eaten—conventionally termed either “wild” or “domesticated” nonhumans—then evolves. This dualistic approach has lifted up the “wild” nonhuman and denigrated enslaved nonhumans, who become seen as separate from rather than as a part of “nature.” The noncaptive “wild” animal becomes the bearer of the dignity and personal values that humans cherish—and which they themselves may feel they have lost in the urbanized, business world,

specifically, freedom and independence—while the majority of nonhumans consumed are seen as the negation of the “wild” and then apparently despised for their enslaved and powerless status.

Removing terminal animals from “nature” as it is conceptualized results not only in the trivialization of their lives, but also in a linguistic structure that uses their names to express contempt: consider the derisory sense of “chicken,” “turkey,” “pig,” and “cow.” This process of circular reasoning, noted by Catharine MacKinnon (1989) in regard to women’s status (that women’s devalued status becomes proof of why women are devalued), results in an ethical stance that harm to a now-degraded individual does not require a human’s attention. Terminal animals are seen as “creatures whose lives appear too slavishly, too boringly, too stupidly female, too ‘cowlike’” to deserve caring about (Davis 1995:196). They become so devalued that mere existence is considered a blessing, thus confirming the legitimacy of their degraded status.

Disembodied suffering is easier to ignore than the direct experience of someone’s suffering. The very size of the problem—nine billion terminal animals (excluding sea animals) in the United States alone—favors objectification of the suffering because the numbers involved are inconceivable. The implications of flesh-eating are simply too big to be comprehended. Innumeracy—mathematical illiteracy—works in favor of the dominant subjectivity. Greek mathematician Archimedes pointed out that a group of small numbers when added together will exceed any large number, no matter how great it is. This “additivity” of small numbers explains how 200 pounds of flesh per person per year translates into more than nine billion land animals. If one doesn’t grasp the additivity of small numbers, he or she won’t see how his or her individual role as a meat eater contributes to the suffering of terminal animals. And so, individual nonhuman bodies disappear as the locus of suffering, the locus of experience, the locus of being a subject.

Becoming a (Male-Identified) Subject

If we prefer definitions of human beings that establish the idea that the human transcends animality, then anything associated with animality or animal-like behavior will be denied, feared, avoided, or destroyed. A clear example of this is the way in which grief is responded to. We encounter an anxious stance that distrusts the body and sees emotions as faulty. Yet, we do everything through our bodies, and sometimes it is grief that reminds us of this.

When we mourn, we experience the physicality of grief. We know this because we feel “truly stricken and stripped.”⁴ Grief, C. S. Lewis reminds us, is agonizingly bodily. After his wife’s death, his journal recorded stomach flutters, yawning, swallowing: “like being mildly drunk, or concussed,” “faint nausea,” “feelings, and feelings, and feelings” (Lewis 1961:31). Grief is not one feeling, but a group of feelings that spiral around—anger, depression, guilt, acceptance, anger, depression, guilt . . . feelings, feelings, feelings. Yet, because both the body and emotions are distrusted, our culture finds grief troubling. The unruly nature of grieving, thus, threatens our sense of how we constitute ourselves as “human.”

Structurally, our culture does not really allow grieving at all: one week if one loses a spouse, two weeks if one loses a child. Then one is supposed to be fully functional. The message is “finish grieving and get back to living.” Yet grief does not work that way. Grief needs acceptance. Often what is substituted for grief is judgment. “I shouldn’t be feeling this way.” “Why are you feeling this way? *Over* this?” In the face of the powerlessness of grief, judgment provides the reassurance of control.

In a culture that is very human oriented, grieving for other humans is barely allowed. Grieving for nonhumans remains largely incomprehensible. Yet, we can’t live fully if we don’t grieve fully, or to put it affirmatively: if we are allowed to grieve fully, we can live fully. To be attentive to terminal animals involves encoun-

tering grief for what they are experiencing. We cannot acknowledge terminal animals as neighbors if we do not allow grief to have a place in our lives.

Each and every day, human beings acknowledge the subject status of the nonhumans with whom they live. And when a certain nonhuman dies, one who was loved deeply, humans find themselves stricken and stripped. Yet when one is grieving for a nonhuman, one is encouraged even more to “get over it”; “it” was “just an animal”; “we’ll get another one.” Again, judgment is interposed where grief should be. In their relationship with a specific animal, humans’ experience a nonhuman’s loyalty, love, companionship, nonjudgmentalism, and individuality. They have experienced the nonhuman as a subject, a very specific who. That is why the death of a nonhuman friend (a “neighbor” in Weil’s terms) is so devastating and the ineptness in responding to it so damaging.⁵

Of all the experiences of childhood that haunt one’s adult years, one in particular is noted in memoirs, interviews, biographies: the death of a “pet.”⁶ Dick Cavett, a talk show host and comedian Joan Rivers, whose husband had committed suicide, once had a discussion on his show about grief. Each of the two celebrities had suffered losses, but the death that had devastated each of them the most, the loss that caused them to be truly stricken and stripped, was the death of a nonhuman animal.

Feeling grief over the death of a nonhuman reveals one’s potential to respond to the suffering of nonhuman animals. In fact, this response is assumed to be so intense that human beings are protected from them. Steve Baker reports, “In 1990 the RSPCA [Royal Society for Prevention of Cruelty to Animals] found itself requested by the Advertising Standards Authority [ASA] to withdraw a press advertisement featuring a photograph of a dead horse suspended from a meat hook in an abattoir, as the ASA thought it likely to cause ‘distress and revulsion’ to the public.” Anti-bullfighting posters were seen as too disturbing as well, so they were

not allowed in British airports (Baker 2001: 222, 224). The responses to individual cases of nonhuman animal suffering that receive media attention, the outpouring of offers of assistance, the ongoing concern, the anger at perpetrators who have harmed specific nonhumans reveal how intense awareness and action on behalf of an individual nonhuman’s suffering can be. How intense and, yet, how feared.

If awareness of nonhuman suffering occurs in our bodies and if these feelings are uncomfortable, and if the body is devalued, then we are blocked from exploring what it means to be aware of nonhuman suffering. Humans are eminently animal because of our grieving. Lots of animals grieve. Humans are the only ones who try to repress, ignore, or minimize this grieving. Consequently, animals are disowned in two ways—humans disown their own animal bodies, and this allows humans to disown the other animals.

Several animal rights leaders have described to me how the mind/body dualism and the untrustworthy view of emotional responses to suffering influenced their lives. They spent years insisting they did not care for other animals because they did not feel caring would be seen as an appropriate response. They needed to appear rational, “in control,” distanced from nonhuman animals. With the appearance of ecofeminist writings on nonhumans, they felt such relief because they now had a language that legitimated the idea that one might care for nonhumans and that this was an appropriate motivation for activism.

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“Be a Man” Subjectivity

When a child grieves the death of a beloved nonhuman friend, when a sobbing 4-H teenager watches his prizewinning nonhuman companion sold to become flesh, when an adolescent resists learning how to hunt, the response is often “be a man.” The lesson is that subjectification and adulthood occur at the expense of another’s

subject status as well as that one's own bodily responses are unreliable and must be conquered. I am going to call this "Be a Man" subjectivity. It involves a demand to ignore feelings, to distrust the body, and shoulder the responsibility of disengagement. The "man of reason," in this case the flesh eater, must deny his (or her) own body and its sensations of unease, concern, sadness, revulsion, etc. to pursue the cultural privilege of treating nonhumans as objects. Through "be a man" subjectivity, something else happens as well, something with religious implications regarding a suffering caused by dominance over others. To avoid recognizing such suffering, an individual is taught to identify with those causing the suffering, with those in power, not with those who are suffering and powerless, to accept the consciousness of the dominant not the dominated.⁷

Consequently, one identifies with the consumer not the consumed, the subject not the object. Engaging with the suffering of nonhumans requires, in most cases, acknowledging a suffering that humans themselves are causing. This is not comfortable. The agential role of the dominant subject must disappear as well as any reminders of the dominated animal subject. We encounter the triumph of phallic discourse that assumes sacrifice needs to be made (by others). Thus we hear about giving thanks to terminal animals for sacrificing themselves. The only volition apparently granted nonhumans is the desire to die for humans. If nonhumans really wanted to sacrifice themselves for us, why, when Cinci Freedom was given the choice between life or death, did she leap over the six-foot fence? And if we are truly comfortable with the idea that nonhumans make this ultimate sacrifice for us, why was she not sent back to the meat packers after her escape, so that we could, as David Lynch called it, "Eat Her Fear"? Perhaps this is why the use of pornographic constructs in meat advertisements exist: the animals' imputed desire to die for humans takes on sexualized overtones. The individual pig, cow, chicken, is transformed not only into the mass

term, "pork," "beef," "chicken," but further into being depicted as a "hooker" awaiting not just consumption, but consummation. They "want it."⁸ The result is the "heroic" meal of a dead nonhuman which situates the eater as active and virile, the conqueror of his emotions. The pragmatic legacy of male subjectivity is the ability to dismiss nonhumans' suffering.

This movement away from engaging with a subject occurs through denial. First, something happens—a personal experience of reading, talking, seeing something, feeling something, a hint of discomfort. Something makes us aware that we are not eating just "food." This initial thought may be momentary, a glimpse of another's subjectivity: "I am eating a once-living cow." Such awareness can easily be dismissed. "This doesn't matter" or "I can't bear to think about nonhuman's suffering" and awareness is moved elsewhere. Or one can accept awareness as a gift of the religious imagination. The question becomes, "What am I going to do with awareness?" And the answer can be: "I need to engage with it." Following awareness leads to attention.

Attention is when one can respond to the insights awareness raises within without fear, rejection, or control. For example: "Dairy. Oh, it comes from cows. Cows suffer. But I want a cheese pizza." If the cheese pizza is more important and immediate than this awareness, attention to what happens to cows will be resisted. The cow becomes an absent referent, a mass term, so trivialized that her fate is immaterial.

Awareness interrupted, deflected, or denied can lead to guilt and defensiveness. Though it is thought that becoming a vegan requires energy, in fact, *not* becoming a vegan requires energy too. The difference is that vegans can follow awareness about terminal animals' suffering, rather than using their energy constantly to derail attention or subdue guilt. Nonvegans must block or redirect awareness of their neighbors. When awareness leads to attention, and attention to engagement, feelings about nonhumans' suffering are not frightening. The indi-

vidual’s agential role in causing suffering has ended. “I want the pizza. But if I eat the pizza, I am compromising my own commitment to not causing nonhumans’ suffering. How can I keep this commitment? I could have a non-cheese pizza.”

If one knows one is being inconsistent, the response may be to defend oneself against this knowledge, rather than to acknowledge that one is being inconsistent. “What I am doing cannot survive close scrutiny, it does not accord with my idea of my own—and others—humanity. It clashes with the values I believe I have. So, I am going to distort this action, split it apart from everything else, and do everything to defend myself against the realization.”⁹ The more people are uncomfortable with what they are doing, the more they will have to defend it. Because discomfort, too, is a feeling, and feelings are viewed as untrustworthy, subjects who require objects to complete their subjectivity will find ways to *continue* disowning any animal-identified feeling.

In this culture, women are supposed to do the emotional work for heterosexual intimate relationships: “a man will come to expect that a woman’s role in his life is to take care of his feelings and alleviate the discomfort involved in feeling” (Bathrick et al 1987:39). This could be one reason women outnumber men in the animal rights movement. Even at the cultural level, women may be doing the emotional work of responding to the other animals as our neighbors. Whether men or women, animal activists, it could be argued, are doing the unvalued emotional work of our culture: They are attentive.

While the process of objectifying someone is an essential aspect of the “master” or dominant subjectivity, we are actually taught a myth about the construction of the subject—that it occurs autonomously. The idea of the construction of a separate and individual self directly reflects the masculinist predilection to make invisible the context and interconnections between people and all living things (Kaschak 1992:136, 150). In fact, we become subjects in re-

lationship to other subjects. Each “man of reason” became one through relationships. Feminist philosopher Lorraine Code (1991) points out, drawing upon the work of Annette Baier, we do not begin as autonomous, unlocatable knowers of the world, we begin as “second persons.” We are the second-person “you” to others who feed us, teach us to walk, instruct us on the dangers of a hot stove. This is how we initially acquire our knowledge. As opposed to the idea of the atomistic individual gaining knowledge of the world by oneself, we become persons through our dependence upon other persons from whom we “acquire the essential arts of personhood.” Code explains that the concept of second persons demonstrates “the communal basis of moral and mental activity. . . . A human being could not become a person, in any of the diverse senses of the term, were she or he *not* in ‘second person’ contact from earliest infancy.”¹⁰ (Code 1991:82) Lives begin in communality and interdependence; thus our acquisition of knowledge is not atomistically individualistic or “self-made” (Code 1991).

We learn in and through relationships with others, and, importantly, these relationships are not only among other humans, but also include nonhumans. Children, especially, constitute a self that relates to other beings as peers. Gail Melson (2001) proposes that children form what could be called a naïve biology. She argues that developmental psychologists have ignored this aspect of a child’s growth. A central problem in acknowledging other animals as neighbors, therefore, is that the relationships that were formative to us as children become disowned or “outgrown” as we move into the framework of the “adult” world; the “second person” nature of the relationships that obtained for many in childhood—relationships that included respect for and learning from other animals—is buried within “be a man” subjectivity that maintains a fiction of autonomy and an autonomous education. Indeed, the relationship between the adult world and the child’s world is recapitulated in the relationship between the dominant culture

and the animal rights movement. Animal activists are told to “get a life” (“grow up”) as though activism on behalf of animals is not a life, or at least not a mature one. People who care about nonhumans’ suffering are seen as caring “too much.” They are called “Bambi vegetarians”—i.e., they never got over their childhood experience of the movie *Bambi* and the shock of the death of Bambi’s mother. Weil observes that attention to a sufferer “is a very rare and difficult thing.” Attention to a nonhuman sufferer is an even more rare and difficult thing.

The God Trick and Terminal Animals’ Existence

Those who cause nonhuman suffering by eating terminal animals and their products must maintain a “be a man” subjectivity, remaining dispassionate, detached, objectifying. Their position must be distanced and aloof, not intertwined and “second person.” Their pleasure that results from oppression becomes instead a privilege that results from entitlement. They disappear as agents who cause harm. In Donna Haraway’s terms, “those occupying the positions of the dominators are self-identical, unmarked, disembodied, unmediated, transcendent, born again” (Haraway 1988:586). Rendered invisible are the structures of oppression that enable such positioning. Haraway argues that knowledge arising from a place where one has the illusion of a view of infinite vision produces unlocatable and thus irresponsible—that is, unable to be called into account—knowledge claims. The result of such epistemologies is to release the knower from any accountability for the claims that emanate from this distanced, apprehensive position. Haraway calls this “the god trick.” Claims about terminal animals that deny them subject status or dispute whether they suffer or are conscious of suffering—these claims are evidence of a god trick. Such arguments require distance. Staying unlocatable and unaccountable makes one much more able to accept the suffering of terminal animals because one is less likely to en-

counter nonhuman subjects or their suffering. One who is unlocatable and unaccountable has no neighbors.

The tension between responding as a neighbor or enlisting the “god trick” to escape accountability is exemplified in the debate about suffering versus existence. Those who are distanced from suffering, who are unlocatable, often claim that “at least the animals were born.” To those who benefit from oppression, the simple fact of terminal animals’ existence mitigates the suffering inherent to that state of existence. Because the victims have been trivialized, the issue of their suffering can be trivialized as well. Queries about nonhumans that pose the question, “why else are they here?” position humans in their relationship to nonhuman animals as akin to God’s relationship to humans. Humans become the reason for terminal animals’ existence. The question, “What would happen to the cows if we didn’t eat them?” implies that terminal animals are the only oppressed group for whom the elimination of their oppression appears to eliminate them. This allows for the comforting belief that God-like, we have been beneficent in granting life and so we can take it when we desire. What of the suffering in between? It disappears. By claiming the credit for the existence of terminal animals, (and so it is the meat eaters’ need to eat meat that allows for the existence of animals who become “meat”), nonvegans commit an error in logic, (terminal animals were born because we wish to objectify them, so since they are born, we can use them as objects). At the same time, nonvegans create a belief system that implicitly forgives themselves for what they cause nonhumans to experience.

All of this is based on fallacious reasoning: One who is not born cannot actually regret one’s nonexistence.¹¹ In fact, there is no state of nonexistence from which existence can be judged. Once one exists, the issue becomes the quality of that individual’s life, and the ethical issue for humans must be one of attention to our neighbors, the farmed animals.

When the ethical issue is framed so that it appears the only option for terminal animals is existence with suffering *or* nonexistence, the either/or thinking that is an aspect of an oppressive worldview is evident. Such either/or thinking conveniently eliminates the ethical perspective that existence *without* suffering is a possibility. But it is only a possibility if humans take responsibility for the suffering they cause terminal animals. Instead, through the “god trick,” persons who establish such an either/or framework for a debate about meat eating, situate themselves as unlocatable in relationship to the suffering of nonhumans. They cannot and will not be neighbors in Weil’s sense of the word. The belief that existence is good in and of itself arises from a disembodied rationalized position. Although their subjectivity depends on the erasure of the other, this position makes a suspect epistemological claim—that despite their role in dominating animals, they believe they can speak for what the animals experience. The nonhuman other who exists to become “meat” is needed for the dominator’s gratification.

Bernard Rollin (1990) asserts that “to be morally responsive to pain in animals, one must ideally know animals in *their individuality*.” This is precisely what the god trick precludes. Instead, someone who is “up” dismisses the issue of suffering as immaterial or nonexistent precisely because they have experienced its materiality only in regards to their own narcissistic pleasures and not in relationship to the other individual’s experience of suffering. As Simone Weil reminds us, “Those who are unhappy have no need for anything in this world but people capable of giving them attention” (Weil 1971:75). Weil herself understood that such attention is transformative and miraculous.

ates a narcissistic need *not* to know. As a result, human self-definition evolves split off from acknowledging relationships in which we are the cause of nonhumans’ suffering.

Attention to suffering makes us ethically responsible.¹² Only those who are “up” can deny the ethical implications of suffering for those who are “down.” Simone Weil suggests that love of our neighbor, in its fullness, means being able to ask, “What are you going through?” and to be able to be attentive to the answer. The question, Weil says, “is a recognition that the sufferer exists, not only as a unit in a collection,” but as an individual. To be able to ask of nonhumans, “What are you going through?” requires a sense of the self that is related and interdependent, involved with others. Val Plumwood calls this the “ecological self”: “one which includes the goal of the flourishing of earth others and the earth community among its own primary ends, and hence respects or cares for these others for their own sake” (Plumwood 1993:154). Seeing ourselves as born into relationships rather than as atomistic, self-made individuals, and recognizing that these valued relationships include other animals, can challenge the boundary between the presumably “self-made (hu)man” and the presumably “nature-made animal,” between the subject and the putative object, between “doer” and the “done to.” This requires that subjectivity be redefined—freed from its death dance with an objectified other.

It is the quality of relationship that we have with each other, human and nonhuman, that matters. Attention to others, as Weil states, involves being able to ask “what are you going through?” and being able to acknowledge that we can, in relationship with animals, understand their answers. Attention to another’s suffering means that we may feel pain, alarm, anguish, and guilt. We may encounter deep grief, both for what they are going through, and what we caused them to experience.

For those who care about the suffering of nonhumans, the stages of grief Elisabeth Kubler Ross enumerated are configured somewhat dif-

Resume close
reading here

Changing the Subject

Fearing that we care too much, we create structures that enable us to care too little. It could be argued that this value hierarchical structure cre-

ferently. The final stage is not “acceptance.” Nonhuman suffering is not inevitable. The “ecological self,” the interdependent self, the second-person subject need not make peace with the inevitability of the (human-willed) death of terminal animals. Instead, we will understand that grief will be a daily presence. Because of the extensive ways in which humans are harming nonhumans, grief will be the companion to attention. Attention allows human beings to be fully human as they acknowledge how humans and nonhumans are interrelated.

Changing the object status of nonhumans involves changing the subjectification process of humans. What is needed is a theology of relinquishment in which subjectivity does not arise from the object status of others. Instead, each subject, each ecological self, is able to acknowledge the grieving/feeling aspect of one's own self. An ethic of attention to others is actively embodied—acknowledging the other's body and its capacity for suffering and one's own body and its capacity to feel grief. Then one can become a good neighbor, and transform one's own body from being a locus of oppression

through consumption of dead animal bodies to being a locus of change—one that survives on plant food instead.

We require a self-in-relation that is not bound by species-identification. Many people report that they could not eat a nonhuman after looking into her or his eyes. They realized there was a “who” there, as desirous of living as Cinci Freedom. Redemption, it could be claimed, is related to bodily integrity, to trusting our bodies, our bodies' authority. What we need is not “I” language, from a separate, autonomous subject, but “eye,” “hand,” and “ear” language, able to acknowledge the many ways that nonhumans answer the question, “What are you going through?”

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NOTES

1. For ecofeminist work generally see Plumwood (1993), Adams (1993), Gray (1982), Warren (1987), Ruether (1991), and Diamond and Orenstein (1990). for ecofeminist approaches to animals see Adams (1990, 1994), Gaard, Adams and Donovan (1995), Donovan and Adams (1996). A comprehensive bibliography of works that deal specifically with women and animals and/or feminism and animal defense theory can be found in Adams and Donovan (1995:353–61).

2. I take as a given that terminal animals—those animals who are raised to become humans' “meat”—suffer. Space does not allow the defense of this claim, but since the literature on the subject is plentiful, I direct any reader who doubts this claim to the following: Coats (1989), Dunayer (2001), Eis-

entz (1997), Mason and Singer (1980), Rollin (1990), Singer (1990).

3. See Dunayer (2001) for a persuasive analysis of the problem of language in *Animal Equality*.

4. Insight of Martha Murphy Hall, Dallas, spring 2001.

5. In *Prayers for Animals* (2004) and *God Listens When You're Sad: Prayers When Your Animal Friend Is Sick or Dies* (2005), I have created prayers to acknowledge grief at the death of animal friends.

6. On the failure of psychological theory to address children's relationship to nonhumans, see Melson (2001).

7. Thanks to Gus Kaufman, Jr. for suggesting this as a response to suffering.

8. On this see Adams (2003).

9. Kovel (1971:19) summarizes this thought process, ‘‘Since this set of ideas is inconsistent and will stand neither the test of reason nor of my better values, I am going to distort it, split it up, and otherwise defend myself against the realization.’’

10. Code (1991) is quoting Annette Baier, ‘‘Cartesian Persons,’’ in *Postures of the Mind: Essays*

on *Mind and Morals* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press).

11. See my discussion of this issue in Adams (1994:69–70).

12. Donovan’s work (1990, 1994) has been extremely influential in the formulation of my own position.

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